Understanding Theme with Fables — Set 3

Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

Directions: Read each fable. Write its moral or theme, then explain which events support your answer. The moral is not stated in the story.

1. The Beaver and the Broken Bridge

A beaver built a narrow bridge of branches across a stream. His neighbor, an otter, warned him that the branches were too loose. The beaver replied that he had crossed it many times and saw no reason to change it. One rainy morning the current grew strong, and the bridge collapsed just as the beaver stepped onto it. The otter helped him reach the bank. The next day the beaver listened carefully as they built a stronger bridge together.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

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Explain how your answer relates to the story. Use evidence from the events.

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2. The Sparrow and the Shiny Pebble

A sparrow found a beautiful blue pebble beside a garden path. She carried it everywhere, proud of how it sparkled. When she discovered a patch of ripe berries, she could not pick any up without putting down the pebble. She tried balancing both, but the berries kept falling. By the time she chose to set the pebble aside, the other birds had eaten most of the fruit. She finally realized that the pebble had filled her beak but not her stomach.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

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Explain how your answer relates to the story. Use evidence from the events.

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3. The Fox and the Quiet Hedgehog

A fox laughed whenever the hedgehog moved slowly through the woods. One afternoon, smoke drifted between the trees. The fox raced in circles, searching for the safest way out. The hedgehog stopped, felt the breeze, and followed a damp streambed away from the smoke. The fox noticed and followed him to a clearing. Once safe, the fox thanked the animal he had mocked.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

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Explain how your answer relates to the story. Use evidence from the events.

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4. The Two Goats and the Orchard

Two goats discovered a fallen apple beneath a fence. Each insisted that the apple belonged to him. They pulled and pushed until the apple rolled into a muddy ditch. A nearby rabbit suggested they search under the tree instead of fighting. Behind the fence they found several more fallen apples. The goats shared the fruit and wondered why they had wasted so much time arguing over one.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

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Explain how your answer relates to the story. Use evidence from the events.

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5. The Owl and the Morning Song

An owl wanted the forest birds to admire his singing. He practiced every night, but no one was awake to listen. One evening a little mouse suggested that the owl sing at sunset, when both daytime and nighttime animals were nearby. The owl disliked changing his routine, yet he tried the idea. At sunset, a small crowd gathered and enjoyed his song. He thanked the mouse for offering a different point of view.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

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Explain how your answer relates to the story. Use evidence from the events.

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6. The Tortoise and the Seed

A tortoise planted a seed near his burrow and watered it every morning. A young rabbit visited after three days and laughed because nothing had appeared. The tortoise continued caring for the soil. Weeks passed before a tiny green shoot emerged. By summer it had become a plant with broad leaves that shaded the tortoise on hot afternoons. The rabbit asked how he had grown it so quickly, and the tortoise smiled at the many quiet mornings of work.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

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Explain how your answer relates to the story. Use evidence from the events.

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Answer Key — Set 3

Sample answers; accept other reasonable themes supported by evidence.

1. The Beaver and the Broken Bridge

Theme: Wise people listen to helpful advice.

Evidence: The beaver ignored a warning, suffered when the bridge collapsed, and later accepted help and advice.

2. The Sparrow and the Shiny Pebble

Theme: Value what is useful over what merely looks impressive.

Evidence: The sparrow clung to a pretty pebble and missed the chance to gather food.

3. The Fox and the Quiet Hedgehog

Theme: Do not judge others by appearances or speed.

Evidence: The supposedly slow hedgehog stayed calm and found a safe route while the quick fox panicked.

4. The Two Goats and the Orchard

Theme: Cooperation solves problems better than needless arguing.

Evidence: Fighting cost the goats their first apple; working together helped them find enough to share.

5. The Owl and the Morning Song

Theme: Being willing to change your approach can bring success.

Evidence: The owl adjusted when he sang after listening to the mouse and finally found an audience.

6. The Tortoise and the Seed

Theme: Patience and steady effort lead to results.

Evidence: The tortoise kept watering the seed even when growth was not visible, and eventually the plant flourished.